From Algorithm to Resolve: AI-based Conflict Forecasting and Public Support for Preventive Humanitarian Intervention

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Abstract

This project examines whether and how computational conflict forecasting shapes public support for preventive humanitarian intervention. Existing research has primarily focused on improving predictions of political violence or examining public attitudes toward humanitarian intervention after civilian suffering becomes visible. Less is known about whether predictive information can generate support for preventive action before large-scale violence occurs. We argue that computational conflict forecasts can increase public support for preventive intervention by raising the perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation, thereby strengthening citizens' sense of moral responsibility to protect civilians and their willingness to accept the associated intervention costs. We further examine whether these effects depend on the forecasting system's reported predictive performance and citizens' preexisting attitudes toward AI and educational attainment. To test these expectations, we design a randomized vignette experiment involving approximately 2,000 respondents in the United States. Respondents evaluate a hypothetical humanitarian crisis in an African country and are randomly assigned to one of five conditions varying the presence, informational source, and reported predictive performance of early-warning assessments. We examine the effects of these treatments on perceived escalation likelihood, support for preventive military intervention, perceived moral responsibility, and cost acceptability, alongside a supplementary measure of confidence in the available information. By investigating how citizens interpret and respond to predictive warnings, this study advances our understanding of whether computational conflict forecasting can help translate early-warning information into public support for preventive humanitarian action.

1. Introduction

Preventive humanitarian intervention poses a distinctive political dilemma. Governments may have strong reasons to act before large-scale violence occurs, since early intervention can prevent crises from becoming more severe, costly, and difficult to contain (George, 2000; Karreth & Tir, 2013; Beardsley et al., 2017). Yet prevention also requires action under uncertainty: before violence has fully materialized, the humanitarian consequences that intervention seeks to avert remain prospective, while the political, financial, and human costs of intervention are immediate and visible. The 1994 genocide in Rwanda starkly illustrates the consequences of delayed action. Reflecting on the international response four years later, President Bill Clinton acknowledged that the international community "did not act quickly enough after the killing began," while subsequent U.S. policy emphasized the need to identify warning signs and respond to atrocities at an earlier stage (Scheffer, 1998; U.S. Department of State, 1999). At the same time, acting early can expose leaders to domestic criticism if military deployments appear unnecessary, costly, or excessively risky, particularly when the feared catastrophe has not yet occurred. This tension was evident during the 2011 Libya crisis, when President Barack Obama warned of the "potential for mass murder of innocent civilians" while simultaneously ruling out the deployment of U.S. ground troops (Obama, 2011a). In subsequently explaining the intervention, Obama emphasized the "costs and risks of intervention" and stressed that action could be undertaken without putting American troops on the ground (Obama, 2011b). Preventive humanitarian action therefore confronts democratic leaders with a central political challenge: how to justify certain and immediately observable costs in response to harms that remain uncertain and not yet fully visible.

Recent advances in conflict forecasting offer one possible way to address this informational challenge. Improvements in data availability, computational methods, and Artificial Intelligence (AI) increasingly allow researchers and policy organizations to estimate where and when violent conflict is likely to occur (Hegre et al., 2017; Cederman & Weidmann, 2017; Murphy et al., 2024). By combining diverse indicators into systematic, forward-looking assessments of escalation risk, forecasting systems can provide information that is difficult to derive from fragmented observations alone. These tools are increasingly used in humanitarian planning, displacement forecasting, peacekeeping, and early-warning systems (Duursma & Karlsrud, 2019; Beduschi, 2022; Kjærum & Madsen, 2025). Their political significance may therefore extend beyond prediction itself. By making the prospective consequences of inaction more concrete and credible, conflict forecasts may help governments justify preventive action before a crisis reaches its most destructive stage.

Better warning, however, does not necessarily produce preventive action. Research on early warning has long identified a warning–response gap in which even timely and credible information may fail to generate a political response because decision-makers confront uncertainty about appropriate policy options, concerns about false alarms, and the costs of intervention (George & Holl, 1997; Austin, 2004; Meyer et al., 2020). One potentially important part of this gap is public opinion. Existing research shows that citizens evaluate humanitarian intervention through moral, instrumental, and international-legitimacy considerations (Kreps & Maxey, 2018; Dill & Schubiger, 2021; Wallace, 2019; Mazepus et al., 2024), but most studies examine crises in which civilian suffering is already observable. Much less is known about whether predictive information can generate public support for acting before such suffering has occurred, or whether its political effects depend on the reliability of the forecast.

This study examines whether computational conflict forecasting can help bridge the gap between prediction and preventive action. We design a randomized vignette experiment among

adults in the United States, in which respondents evaluate a hypothetical humanitarian crisis before large-scale fighting has begun. The experiment varies the presence, informational source, and reported predictive performance of early-warning assessments, comparing AI-based conflict forecasts with the absence of an explicit warning and qualitative assessments by local experts. We examine whether AI-based forecasts increase perceived likelihood of conflict escalation and public support for preventive humanitarian intervention, whether stronger reported predictive performance amplifies these effects, and whether citizens' preexisting perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits condition their responses. We further investigate whether perceived likelihood of conflict escalation mediates the effects of computational forecasting on intervention support. We also examine how early-warning information shapes citizens' evaluations of the moral justification and cost acceptability. In doing so, the study shifts attention from whether conflict can be forecast accurately to whether predictive information can become politically actionable before large-scale violence occurs.

2. Humanitarian Crises, Uncertainty, and Public Opinion on Preventive Intervention

Humanitarian intervention occupies a distinctive position in public attitudes toward the use of force abroad. Compared with interventions pursued for objectives such as regime change or other forms of internal political change, humanitarian missions generally receive relatively high levels of public support (Jentleson, 1992; Jentleson & Britton, 1998; Eichenberg, 2005; Brownlee, 2020; Kiratli, 2024; Levin & Musgrave, 2025). A central explanation is their moral purpose: because humanitarian interventions aim to protect civilians from large-scale violence, citizens may view them as fulfilling a moral obligation rather than simply advancing strategic interests (Kreps & Maxey, 2018; Tomz et al., 2020; Chu & Lee, 2024). At the same time, public support also depends on instrumental and procedural considerations, including the expected effectiveness and costs of intervention and whether the operation is internationally authorized (Dill & Schubiger, 2021; Mazepus et al., 2024; Wallace, 2019). Citizens may therefore endorse the objective of civilian protection while remaining reluctant to support an operation that appears costly, risky, ineffective, or insufficiently legitimate (Davies & Johns, 2016).

Most of this literature, however, examines crises in which civilian suffering is already visible. Preventive humanitarian action poses a different political problem because it must be undertaken before large-scale violence has fully materialized.[1] This timing can be consequential: once conflict escalates, intervention may become more difficult and costly, while opportunities for lower-cost preventive measures narrow (George, 2000; Karreth & Tir, 2013; Beardsley et al., 2017). Yet acting earlier also means acting under greater uncertainty. Citizens may be asked to support diplomatic initiatives, humanitarian assistance, financial commitments, or military deployments when it is still unclear whether violence will escalate, how severe it will become, or whether intervention will ultimately prove necessary (George & Holl, 1997; George, 2000; Muggah & Whitlock, 2022). Preventive intervention therefore creates an asymmetry between uncertain future benefits and immediate, visible costs: the civilians who may be protected have not yet suffered the anticipated harm, while the burdens of intervention are incurred in the

[1] A partial exception is Levin & Musgrave (2025), who examine support for interventions intended to prevent prospective crimes against humanity, although their focus is on electoral intervention rather than preventive military action.

present.

This uncertainty creates a political constraint for both national and international actors. Democratic governments may find it difficult to justify costly preventive measures when the threat remains probabilistic, while international organizations must decide whether uncertain risks warrant scarce diplomatic attention, personnel, and resources. Existing research on UN conflict prevention shows that preventive engagement is more likely when escalation risks become visible through signals such as previous violence or regional contagion, while less immediately observable predictors of future conflict attract less consistent action (White et al., 2018; Cunningham et al., 2026). These institutional decisions are also embedded in a broader political environment shaped by member-state support and public legitimacy (Dellmuth & Tallberg, 2021; Sommerer & Tallberg, 2026). Public attitudes may therefore matter not only for whether national governments undertake preventive action, but also for the political feasibility of international preventive efforts.

Historical cases illustrate this problem. Prior to and during the 1994 genocide in Rwanda, international actors received substantial warning of organized mass violence, yet those warnings failed to generate an adequate preventive response (George & Holl, 1997; Meyer et al., 2020). In Bosnia, policymakers likewise confronted uncertainty about the trajectory of the conflict alongside concerns about the costs and casualties associated with military involvement, contributing to delayed and limited intervention as civilian violence intensified (George, 2000). These cases suggest that failures of prevention cannot be understood solely as failures to detect danger. They also reflect the difficulty of justifying immediate action against consequences that remain uncertain at the moment when prevention is still possible.

This leaves an important gap in the literature on public opinion and humanitarian intervention. Existing studies tell us a great deal about how citizens evaluate intervention once humanitarian suffering is apparent, but much less about how they respond when the case for action rests on expectations about future violence. If uncertainty makes preventive action harder to justify politically, then the availability of credible information about escalation risk may be consequential for public support.

3. Conflict Forecasting and the Politics of Preventive Action

Conflict forecasting offers one possible way to reduce this informational constraint. Advances in computational methods and data availability have improved researchers' ability to estimate where and when violence is likely to occur, moving beyond slow-moving structural indicators toward more dynamic information on conflict processes (Chadefaux, 2014; Hegre et al., 2017; Cederman & Weidmann, 2017; Murphy et al., 2024). Computational approaches with AI can synthesize these signals into forward-looking assessments of escalation risk, potentially giving decision-makers a more systematic basis for acting before violence fully materializes (Esberg & Mikulaschek, 2021; Beduschi, 2022; Mueller & Rauh, 2022).

These forecasting tools are increasingly being incorporated into practical efforts to support anticipatory action. In the humanitarian sector, predictive systems have been used to anticipate displacement, food insecurity, and humanitarian needs so that resources can be mobilized before crises reach their most severe stage (Beduschi, 2022; Kjærum & Madsen, 2025). In Ukraine, forward-looking estimates of displacement and return patterns have informed humanitarian and social-protection planning under rapidly changing wartime conditions (Krelinova et al., 2025). Predictive analysis has also been proposed within UN peace operations to identify

areas at heightened risk of violence and inform decisions about troop deployment, mediation, civilian protection, and other preventive activities (Duursma & Karlsrud, 2019; Murphy et al., 2024). These applications demonstrate that forecasting can expand the informational basis for acting before escalation closes the preventive window.

Yet improvements in forecasting do not automatically produce improvements in prevention. A longstanding literature on early warning identifies a persistent warning–response gap: timely and credible warnings may still fail to generate action (George & Holl, 1997; Austin, 2004; Meyer et al., 2020). Forecast production is only one stage in a broader political process in which information must be communicated, interpreted, accepted, and connected to feasible responses. Policymakers may discount warnings because crises compete for limited attention, the effectiveness of intervention is uncertain, false alarms carry political and material costs, or action appears premature before violence becomes visible (George & Holl, 1997; Austin, 2004; Muggah & Whitlock, 2022). Indeed, technological advances may generate more numerous or more precise warnings without altering the political incentives that determine whether actors respond (Hirblinger et al., 2024; Meyer et al., 2020). The central challenge is therefore not simply to predict violence more accurately, but to make predictive information politically actionable.

Public opinion is one potential part of this translation process. Preventive foreign policy often requires governments to justify present costs on the basis of anticipated rather than observed harm. Where citizens remain uncertain that violence will escalate, they may regard preventive measures as unnecessary, premature, or insufficiently justified. Conflict forecasts may therefore have political effects beyond improving elite information: by making the risk of future violence more concrete and credible, they may also affect whether citizens regard preventive action as warranted. In this sense, forecasting may help narrow the warning–response gap not only by informing decision-makers, but also by shaping the public environment in which preventive policies must be justified.

Taken together, existing research on conflict forecasting has focused primarily on improving predictive performance and producing more reliable warnings (Hegre et al., 2017; Cederman & Weidmann, 2017; Murphy et al., 2024). Much less is known about how such warnings are received by citizens or whether they can increase the political feasibility of preventive action. This study addresses that gap by asking whether conflict-forecasting information increases public support for preventive humanitarian intervention, whether its effect depends on the reported accuracy of the forecast, and under what conditions predictive warnings are most persuasive.

4. Theory and Hypotheses

This section develops theoretical expectations about how AI-based conflict forecasting shapes public support for preventive humanitarian intervention. The central argument is that preventive intervention presents citizens with an informational problem: the costs of action are immediate, whereas the humanitarian consequences that intervention is intended to prevent remain uncertain. Conflict forecasting can alter this calculation by providing systematic information about whether an emerging crisis is likely to escalate. We therefore focus primarily on how AI-based forecasts shape citizens' perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation and examine whether these informational effects translate into stronger perceptions of moral responsibility and greater willingness to accept the associated intervention costs, thereby leading to greater support for preventive humanitarian intervention.

Average Effects of Conflict Forecasting

Citizens evaluating preventive humanitarian intervention face a distinctive informational challenge: they must decide whether costly action is warranted before the anticipated humanitarian harm has materialized. Unlike responses to ongoing atrocities, preventive intervention requires citizens to assess the likelihood of future violence under conditions of substantial uncertainty. When it remains unclear whether political tensions will escalate into major violence, citizens may be reluctant to support preventive action because the prospective humanitarian benefits of intervention remain uncertain (George & Holl, 1997; George, 2000). Early-warning information may alleviate this constraint by providing citizens with forward-looking assessments of whether an emerging crisis is likely to intensify.

Contemporary conflict-forecasting systems increasingly employ computational methods, including statistical and machine-learning models, to analyze political, economic, and security conditions and generate systematic predictions of future violence (Hegre et al., 2017; Mueller & Rauh, 2022; Murphy et al., 2024). Within this broader category, AI-based forecasting approaches employ techniques associated with artificial intelligence, particularly machine learning, to identify patterns in historical data and generate predictions about future conflict escalation. By integrating multiple indicators and identifying patterns across previous episodes of conflict, AI-based forecasting systems can translate fragmented information about ongoing political tensions into explicit assessments of escalation risk. Rather than merely describing current conditions, these forecasts provide an inference about an outcome that has not yet occurred. Such information may help citizens form clearer expectations about the likelihood of future violence and evaluate whether preventive intervention is warranted.

Research on advice-taking provides a theoretical basis for expecting such forecasts to influence judgments under uncertainty. The Judge–Advisor framework describes how individuals incorporate external information into their judgments when evaluating uncertain outcomes (Sniezek & Buckley, 1995; Yaniv & Kleinberger, 2000; Soll & Mannes, 2011). Individuals confronting an uncertain situation may initially hold incomplete or weakly formed beliefs, making their judgments particularly responsive to additional diagnostic information. A conflict forecast that explicitly assesses the probability of future escalation can therefore provide an informational anchor around which citizens update their expectations about an emerging crisis.

This logic suggests that the most fundamental effect of AI-based conflict forecasting should emerge relative to situations in which citizens receive no explicit warning about future violence. In the absence of such information, citizens must infer the prospects of escalation from limited descriptions of current political tensions. An AI-based forecast instead provides an explicit, forward-looking assessment that signals that large-scale violence is a plausible future outcome. By converting uncertain developments into a more concrete assessment of future risk, such forecasts should increase the perceived likelihood that the crisis will escalate.

We conceptualize this informational mechanism in terms of *perceived escalation likelihood*, referring to citizens' subjective assessments of the probability that ongoing political tensions will develop into major violence. Under conditions of uncertainty, citizens may find it difficult to determine whether an emerging conflict will intensify, particularly when large-scale violence has not yet occurred. AI-based forecasts may reduce this uncertainty by supplying a systematic assessment of future risk, thereby making the prospect of escalation more salient and credible. Compared with receiving no explicit warning, citizens exposed to an AI-based forecast should therefore perceive major violence as more likely to occur.

These considerations lead to our first hypothesis:

H1a: Citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast will perceive a higher

likelihood of future conflict escalation than citizens who receive no warning about the risk of future violence.

Greater perceived escalation likelihood should, in turn, increase support for preventive humanitarian intervention. Warning scholarship emphasizes that information about impending threats does not automatically generate political action; recipients must regard the anticipated threat as sufficiently serious and decision-relevant to justify a response (Meyer et al., 2020). This requirement is especially consequential for preventive intervention because the anticipated humanitarian consequences have not yet materialized, whereas the financial, political, and military costs of intervention are comparatively immediate. Citizens who perceive escalation as unlikely may therefore regard preventive action as premature or unnecessary. By contrast, when citizens believe that major violence is likely to occur, the expected humanitarian costs of inaction become more consequential. An AI-based forecast can therefore strengthen the perceived justification for preventive intervention by increasing citizens' expectations that the crisis will escalate without preventive action. We consequently expect AI-based warnings to increase support for intervention relative to a situation in which citizens receive no explicit warning.

H1b: Public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be higher among citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast than among citizens who receive no warning about the risk of future violence.

The preceding argument also identifies a mechanism connecting conflict forecasts to support for preventive action. By providing an explicit assessment of future violence, an AI-based warning should increase perceived escalation likelihood, which should in turn strengthen the perceived justification for intervening before major violence occurs. Thus, at least part of the effect of AI-based conflict forecasting on support for preventive humanitarian intervention should operate through changes in citizens' expectations about future conflict.

H1c: The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving no early warning, on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be mediated by an increase in the perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation.

The comparison between AI-based forecasts and warnings derived from qualitative assessments by local experts is theoretically less straightforward. Both forms of warning provide citizens with information indicating that an emerging crisis may escalate. The relevant question is therefore not whether citizens receive forward-looking information, but whether the *source and form* of that information affect the weight citizens assign to the warning.

There are reasons to expect AI-based forecasts to exert greater influence. Computational forecasting systems systematically integrate multiple indicators and compare current conditions with patterns observed across a broader range of previous cases (Hegre et al., 2017; Mueller & Rauh, 2022). Research on humanitarian anticipatory action similarly emphasizes the potential of computational models to synthesize diverse sources of information and detect emerging threats before large-scale harm occurs (Beduschi, 2022). Citizens may consequently regard numerical, data-driven forecasts as systematic, consistent, and comparatively objective assessments of future risk.

Research on algorithm appreciation reinforces this possibility. Individuals do not necessarily assign equal weight to advice generated by different sources. Logg et al. (2019), for example, show that individuals sometimes rely more heavily on algorithmic advice than on human judgments, including in geopolitical forecasting tasks involving lay participants. Similarly,

Bogert et al. (2022) find that algorithmic advice can increase reliance on external information and confidence in subsequent judgments even when advice quality is held constant. If citizens associate AI-based forecasts with systematic analysis, greater consistency, or superior processing of complex information, they may assign greater evidentiary weight to an AI warning than to a qualitatively derived warning from human experts.

This reasoning produces an *algorithmic-advantage expectation*: even when both sources indicate that violence is likely to occur, an AI-based forecast may generate a stronger change in perceived escalation likelihood because citizens regard its data-driven methodology as providing a particularly systematic basis for anticipating future events.

> **H2a-A:** Citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast will perceive a higher likelihood of future conflict escalation than citizens who receive an early warning based on qualitative assessments by local experts.

However, there are also theoretical reasons why qualitative warnings from local experts may be at least as influential as, or potentially more influential than, AI-based forecasts. Local NGOs, community leaders, and regional specialists possess contextual knowledge that may be difficult to capture through statistical indicators alone. Their assessments can incorporate political relationships, local grievances, elite intentions, rapidly changing events, and other contextual developments that may not be readily observable in structured data. Citizens may therefore regard individuals with direct knowledge of local conditions as particularly well positioned to judge whether a crisis is likely to escalate.

Moreover, the advantages associated with algorithmic advice are not universal. Reliance on algorithms depends on how individuals evaluate the competence, transparency, and appropriateness of the source. In settings characterized by political complexity and contextual ambiguity, citizens may regard human expertise as more suitable for interpreting the intentions and behavior of political actors. An assessment explicitly attributed to regional conflict experts drawing on reports from local NGOs and community leaders may consequently carry substantial epistemic authority. If citizens place greater value on contextual expertise and proximity to events than on computational processing, qualitative warnings may exert an equal or stronger influence on their expectations of future violence.

This alternative reasoning produces a *contextual-expertise expectation*:

> **H2a-B:** Citizens who receive an early warning based on qualitative assessments by local experts will perceive a higher likelihood of future conflict escalation than citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast.

These competing expectations have corresponding implications for support for preventive humanitarian intervention. If citizens assign greater evidentiary weight to AI-generated forecasts, an AI warning should make the anticipated humanitarian consequences of inaction more compelling and thereby generate greater support for preventive intervention than a qualitative warning. Conversely, if citizens place greater weight on the contextual knowledge and judgment of local experts, qualitative warnings may provide a stronger basis for preventive action.

We therefore formulate competing hypotheses concerning the relative effects of the two forms of warning:

> **H2b-A:** Public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be higher among citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast than among citizens who receive a qualitative warning based on assessments by local experts.

H2b-B: Public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be higher among citizens who receive a qualitative warning based on assessments by local experts than among citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast.

Predictive Performance of Conflict Forecasting

The effects of computational conflict forecasts should depend not only on whether predictive information is available, but also on the reported predictive performance of the forecasting system. Preventive humanitarian intervention requires citizens to evaluate potential threats before anticipated violence has fully materialized, when uncertainty about whether escalation will occur is especially high (George & Holl, 1997; George, 2000). Conflict forecasts remain probabilistic rather than definitive statements about future events (Hegre et al., 2017). Consequently, the credibility and informational value of an early warning may depend on the forecasting system's historical ability to anticipate political violence.

A forecasting system with stronger reported predictive performance should provide citizens with greater confidence in the available information about future escalation. When past warnings have frequently been followed by major violence, citizens may regard a new warning as a more reliable indication of an impending threat. Conversely, a weaker record of predictive performance leaves greater doubt about whether the warning signals genuine danger or constitutes a false alarm, a problem long emphasized in the early-warning literature (George & Holl, 1997; Muggah & Whitlock, 2022). Because most citizens are unlikely to evaluate the technical properties of computational forecasting systems directly, information about historical predictive performance may serve as an accessible cue to the reliability of the warning. Higher reported performance should therefore strengthen perceived likelihood of conflict escalation by increasing confidence in the available information and reinforcing beliefs that major violence is likely to occur.

H3a: Citizens who receive an AI-based conflict forecast with higher reported predictive performance will perceive a higher likelihood of future conflict escalation than those who receive an otherwise identical forecast with lower reported predictive performance.

Greater perceived likelihood of future conflict should, in turn, increase support for preventive humanitarian intervention. Decisions about preventive action require citizens to weigh the potential consequences of failing to intervene against the financial, military, and political costs of acting before violence has occurred. Decision-theoretic approaches to conflict prediction emphasize the importance of balancing the costs of false warnings against those of failing to respond to genuine threats (Mueller & Rauh, 2022; Kjærum & Madsen, 2025). When citizens regard an early warning as more reliable, the anticipated consequences of inaction may become more compelling, making preventive intervention appear more justified despite its associated costs. Accordingly, stronger reported predictive performance should increase public support for preventive humanitarian intervention. Whereas a warning with a weaker performance record may leave citizens reluctant to endorse costly preventive action, a warning supported by a stronger historical record may provide a more persuasive informational basis for intervention. This expectation is consistent with arguments that the political influence of early warnings depends on whether their recipients regard them as credible and sufficiently persuasive to justify a response (Meyer et al., 2020).

H3b: Public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be higher among citizens who receive a AI-based conflict forecast with higher reported predictive performance than among those who receive an otherwise identical forecast with lower reported predictive performance.

The preceding arguments suggest that perceived likelihood of conflict escalation constitutes a potential mechanism linking the reported predictive performance of computational forecasts to public support for preventive intervention. Stronger historical performance may increase confidence in the available information and reinforce expectations of impending violence. These informational perceptions may subsequently make the anticipated threat more compelling and strengthen citizens' willingness to support preventive military action. Thus, the effect of reported predictive performance on intervention support should operate, at least in part, through increased perceived likelihood of conflict escalation.

H3c: The positive effect of higher reported predictive performance on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be mediated by increased perceived likelihood of conflict escalation.

Attitudes toward AI's Functional Capabilities and the Effects of Conflict Forecasting

The effects of computational conflict forecasting may depend on citizens' preexisting perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits. Individuals who regard AI as capable, useful, and effective may be more inclined to consider computational forecasts credible sources of information about future conflict risks. Such predispositions may increase the weight they assign to AI-generated predictions when evaluating the likelihood of conflict escalation, particularly when compared with receiving no early warning or a qualitative assessment from local experts. By contrast, individuals with less favorable perceptions of AI may be more skeptical of computational forecasts and less willing to incorporate their predictions into assessments of future violence. Favorable perceptions of AI may also reduce sensitivity to information about predictive performance. Individuals who already regard AI as capable and reliable may maintain confidence in computational forecasts even when their reported predictive performance is relatively low, whereas those with less favorable attitudes may rely more heavily on reported precision when assessing their credibility. Accordingly, favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits should amplify the effects of receiving computational forecasts while attenuating the effects of differences in reported predictive performance on perceived likelihood of conflict escalation.

H4a: The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving no early warning, on perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation will be stronger among citizens with more favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits.

H4b: The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving a qualitative warning from local experts, on perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation will be stronger among citizens with more favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits.

H4c: The positive effect of higher reported predictive performance on perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation will be weaker among citizens with more favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits.

Beyond shaping perceived certainty, preexisting attitudes toward AI may also condition how computational forecasts influence public support for preventive humanitarian intervention. Citizens who regard AI-based predictions as credible and informative may be more willing to treat them as a sufficient evidentiary basis for preventive action before major violence occurs. Consequently, favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits may strengthen the influence of computational forecasts on intervention support, particularly relative to receiving no early warning or a qualitative assessment from local experts. At the same time, individuals with favorable AI attitudes may be less inclined to withdraw support for preventive intervention when a forecast exhibits relatively low predictive performance, as their broader confidence in AI's capabilities may compensate for weaker performance information. Conversely, individuals with less favorable attitudes may be more sensitive to differences in reported precision when deciding whether preventive action is warranted. Thus, favorable perceptions of AI should amplify the effects of receiving computational forecasts while reducing the extent to which reported predictive performance shapes public support for preventive humanitarian intervention.

H4d: The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving no early warning, on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be stronger among citizens with more favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits.

H4e: The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving a qualitative warning from local experts, on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be stronger among citizens with more favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits.

H4f: The positive effect of higher reported predictive performance on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be weaker among citizens with more favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits.

Education Level and the Effect of Conflict Forecasting

Educational attainment may also condition how citizens respond to AI-based conflict forecasts. Individuals with lower levels of education may have fewer opportunities to develop the technical and statistical knowledge necessary to critically evaluate the reliability and limitations of computational predictions. As research on human–AI interaction suggests, limited AI literacy may contribute to excessive reliance on algorithmic recommendations, whereas greater familiarity with AI systems may facilitate more selective evaluations of their outputs (Klingbeil et al., 2024). In the context of conflict forecasting, individuals with lower educational attainment may therefore be more inclined to accept AI-generated warnings as credible indicators of future violence, particularly when compared with receiving no early warning or a qualitative assessment from local experts. At the same time, their limited ability to critically assess predictive information may make them less responsive to differences in reported forecasting performance. Conversely, individuals with higher educational attainment may be better equipped to distinguish between forecasts with stronger and weaker predictive performance, making their assessments of future

conflict escalation more sensitive to reported precision. Thus, lower educational attainment may amplify the effects of receiving an AI-based warning while attenuating the effects of its reported predictive performance on perceived likelihood of conflict escalation.

> **H5a:** The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving no early warning, on perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation will be stronger among citizens with lower educational levels.

> **H5b:** The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving a qualitative warning from local experts, on perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation will be stronger among citizens with lower educational levels.

> **H5e:** The positive effect of higher reported predictive performance on perceived likelihood of future conflict escalation will be weaker among citizens with lower educational levels.

Educational attainment may further shape how AI-generated conflict forecasts translate into public support for preventive humanitarian intervention. Individuals with lower educational attainment may be more likely to rely on computational warnings when forming policy preferences, as they may face greater difficulty independently evaluating the credibility and limitations of predictive assessments. Consequently, the presence of an AI-based warning may exert a stronger influence on their willingness to endorse preventive intervention, particularly relative to receiving no early warning or a qualitative assessment from local experts. However, these individuals may also be less likely to adjust their intervention preferences in response to differences in reported predictive performance, as they may place greater weight on the warning itself than on information about its reliability. By contrast, individuals with higher educational attainment may evaluate the credibility of computational forecasts more selectively, making their willingness to support preventive action more sensitive to differences in predictive precision. Accordingly, lower educational attainment should strengthen the effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention while weakening the effect of reported predictive performance.

> **H5c:** The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving no early warning, on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be stronger among citizens with lower educational levels.

> **H5d:** The positive effect of receiving an AI-based conflict forecast, relative to receiving a qualitative warning from local experts, on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be stronger among citizens with lower educational levels.

> **H5f:** The positive effect of higher reported predictive performance on public support for preventive humanitarian intervention will be weaker among citizens with lower educational levels.

5. Research Design

We test the theoretical expectations using a randomized vignette experiment, building on previous survey-experimental research on public attitudes toward humanitarian intervention and

foreign involvement (Kreps & Maxey, 2018; Kiratli, 2024; Chu & Lee, 2024; Han & Park, 2025). Respondents evaluate a hypothetical political crisis in which the U.S. government considers preventive military intervention before large-scale violence has begun. The experiment employs a five-condition between-subjects design that varies whether an early warning is provided, the informational source underlying the warning, and the reported historical predictive performance of an AI-based forecasting system.

The study will be conducted among approximately 2,000 voting-age adults in the United States recruited through Prolific (https://www.prolific.com). The United States provides a substantively relevant setting because public opinion can constrain government decisions concerning overseas military operations, including humanitarian intervention (Hildebrandt et al., 2013; Maxey, 2020; Tomz et al., 2020). Its historical and contemporary involvement in international military and humanitarian operations also makes the U.S. public particularly relevant for examining political support for preventive action (Jentleson & Britton, 1998; Kreps & Maxey, 2018; Mitkov, 2023; Lai & Reiter, 2005; Chu & Lee, 2024; Lupu & Wallace, 2024).

Sample inclusion and exclusion will follow prespecified eligibility and screening criteria. Participation will be restricted to U.S. residents aged 18 or older who provide informed consent. Before treatment assignment, respondents will complete an attention check and two comprehension questions concerning the common humanitarian-crisis scenario. Respondents who do not provide consent or fail any of the prespecified pretreatment checks will not proceed to randomization. Respondents who discontinue the survey after randomization will be retained in analyses for which they have provided valid outcome responses. For each analysis, observations with missing values on any variables required for the corresponding statistical model will be excluded, without affecting their inclusion in other analyses for which complete data are available. Duplicate submissions will be identified and handled according to prespecified procedures. Importantly, respondents will not be excluded based on their performance on post-treatment numerical-comprehension or treatment-comprehension checks, as such exclusions could introduce post-treatment selection bias. We will report the number of respondents screened, excluded before randomization, assigned to each experimental condition, and included in each analysis, together with the reasons for exclusion. We will also examine whether post-randomization outcome missingness differs across experimental conditions.

Respondents who satisfy the eligibility and pretreatment screening requirements will be randomly assigned to one of five experimental conditions with equal allocation probabilities (20% per condition). Randomization will occur independently at the individual level, without blocking or stratification based on demographic or political characteristics. We aim to obtain approximately 2,000 eligible respondents with completed primary outcome measures, yielding an expected sample of 400 respondents per condition, although realized group sizes may vary due to random assignment and incomplete responses.

Based on this sample size and allocation scheme, we conduct an a priori power analysis assuming a two-sided significance level of 0.05 and 80% statistical power. The minimum detectable standardized mean difference for the principal pairwise treatment comparisons is approximately 0.20 standard deviations. For moderation analyses involving the seven-point AI-attitude measure, treated as a standardized continuous variable, the minimum detectable interaction coefficient is approximately 0.20 outcome standard deviations per one-standard-deviation increase in AI attitudes, assuming approximately unit within-group variance in the moderator. Educational attainment, measured using five ordered categories, will be treated as a categorical moderator, with treatment-effect heterogeneity assessed through interactions between treatment assignment and education-category indicators. Because statistical power for these interactions depends on the distribution of respondents across educational categories and the number of

parameters jointly tested, we do not specify a single minimum detectable effect for education-based moderation. These calculations represent approximate benchmarks based on unadjusted pairwise comparisons.

Before encountering the experimental vignette, respondents complete a pretreatment questionnaire collecting demographic and political characteristics, including gender, age, race, education, household income, geographic location, party identification, and political ideology. These variables provide descriptive information about the sample and allow us to examine heterogeneous treatment effects across relevant demographic and political characteristics. Of particular importance to our theoretical argument, the pretreatment questionnaire measures general attitudes toward artificial intelligence using five items adapted from the General Attitudes toward Artificial Intelligence Scale (Schepman & Rodway, 2020). These items capture favorable perceptions of AI's functional benefits, capabilities, and potential advantages relative to human decision-making. We use them to examine whether individuals with more favorable prior attitudes toward AI respond differently to AI-based early warnings and information concerning forecasting performance.

Hypothetical Humanitarian Crisis

We situate the hypothetical crisis in an unnamed African country. This choice provides a plausible context for preventive humanitarian intervention while limiting the influence of respondents' prior knowledge or attitudes toward a specific country or ongoing conflict. Previous survey experiments have similarly employed hypothetical African settings to investigate public support for foreign intervention (Recchia & Chu, 2021; Mitkov, 2023). Nevertheless, we recognize that the African setting may activate racial, geographic, or paternalistic associations that affect public evaluations of humanitarian intervention (Chu & Lee, 2024). Because the geographic setting remains constant across experimental conditions, such associations do not themselves constitute differences in the randomized information, although they may shape how respondents interpret the warnings.

All respondents receive the same introductory scenario describing an emerging civil war between the government and an armed opposition group. Large-scale fighting has not yet begun, but escalation is expected to result in substantial civilian casualties. This scenario establishes a common humanitarian context in which the potential consequences of escalation are serious but have not yet materialized. Holding the anticipated civilian consequences constant allows us to focus on how information about future escalation, rather than variation in the expected humanitarian costs of violence, shapes public support for preventive intervention. The vignette information is delivered in both written and audio form. The audio recordings were generated using GPT-5.6 and reproduce the substantive content of the written scenarios. Providing the information through both formats is intended to facilitate comprehension of the experimental materials. Respondents are told:

> *Imagine that a civil war may be developing in a foreign country in Africa. Tensions have existed between the government and an armed opposition group, but large-scale fighting has not yet begun.*
>
> *If the situation escalates into major violence, at least several hundred people are expected to be killed during its initial stages. Most of the victims would be civilians*

living in the affected areas, including people who are not directly involved in the fighting. Civilians may also be deliberately targeted as the conflict intensifies.

Following the introductory scenario, respondents complete two comprehension checks concerning whether large-scale fighting has already begun and the expected consequences of escalation. Respondents who fail these checks do not proceed to the randomized warning treatments.

Experimental Treatments: Early-Warning Assessments

Following the common introductory scenario, respondents are randomly assigned to one of five conditions. Each condition presents an announcement by a U.S. government official regarding the developing crisis and a proposed preventive military intervention. Across all conditions, the government is considering deploying approximately 5,000 U.S. military personnel at an estimated cost of around $1 billion to prevent major violence. Holding the proposed military commitment constant allows us to isolate the effects of early-warning information on public evaluations of an otherwise identical intervention proposal.

The five conditions differ in the presence of an explicit early warning, the source of the assessment, and the information provided about its historical predictive performance.

(1) No-Warning Baseline. In the baseline condition, respondents are informed that the U.S. government is closely monitoring the ongoing tensions but that large-scale violence has not yet occurred. The government is considering preventive military intervention, but no explicit forecast concerning the likelihood of escalation is provided. This condition establishes the baseline level of public support for preventive intervention in the absence of an explicit early-warning assessment.

(2) AI-Based Early Warning (w/o Performance Information). In the second condition, respondents receive an explicit warning that major violence is very likely to occur in the near future. The announcement states that the warning is based on an early-warning assessment conducted using artificial intelligence. Respondents are informed that the AI-based system analyzed political, economic, security, and conflict-related information and concluded that the likelihood of escalation into major violence within the next few months is extremely high. No information is provided about the system's historical predictive performance. Comparing this condition with the no-warning baseline identifies the effect of introducing an explicit AI-based early warning, relative to government monitoring without a specific forecast. Because the two conditions differ in both the presence of a warning and its AI-based source, this comparison captures their combined effect rather than the independent effect of AI attribution.

(3) AI-Based Early Warning (w/ 60% Precision). The third condition provides the same AI-based warning but additionally communicates the forecasting system's historical predictive performance. Respondents are informed that the system has a precision of approximately 60%. The announcement explains that when the system issued comparable warnings in the past, major violence followed in approximately six out of ten similar cases. This condition introduces explicit numerical information about the observed reliability of AI-generated warnings.

(4) AI-Based Early Warning (w/ 90% Precision). The fourth condition is identical to the preceding condition except that the reported precision is approximately 90%. Respondents are informed that major violence followed approximately nine out of ten comparable warnings in the past. The randomized comparison between the 60% and 90% conditions identifies the causal effect of communicating stronger historical predictive performance while holding the forecasting source and the qualitative escalation warning constant. The numerical information refers to the frequency with which major violence followed comparable positive warnings rather than the forecasting system's overall classification accuracy. Accordingly, we interpret the contrast as a manipulation of reported positive predictive performance, not necessarily of the unconditional probability that violence will occur in the hypothetical case.

(5) Qualitative Human-based Early Warning. The fifth condition provides an explicit warning that major violence is very likely to occur, but attributes the assessment to regional conflict experts using field reports and contextual analysis. Respondents are informed that the experts reviewed information from local NGOs, community leaders, and other sources familiar with conditions on the ground and concluded that the likelihood of escalation into major violence within the next few months is extremely high. Comparing this condition with the AI-based warning without numerical performance information allows us to examine whether substantively similar warnings have different effects when grounded in AI-based computational analysis rather than qualitative assessments by regional experts. Because the treatments differ in their descriptions of the underlying analytical processes, this contrast captures the effect of the experimentally presented information source and its associated description, rather than a completely isolated AI label.

Experimental Comparisons. The five-condition design permits four principal comparisons. These comparisons allow us to distinguish the influence of warning provision, forecasting source, and reported predictive performance on public support for preventive intervention.

- First, comparing the AI-based warning without performance information with the no-warning baseline assesses the combined effect of receiving an explicit AI-based escalation warning.
- Second, comparing the AI-based warning without performance information with the qualitative expert-based warning assesses whether public responses depend on the analytical source underlying otherwise similar warnings.
- Third, comparing the 90% and 60% AI-warning conditions identifies the effect of stronger reported historical predictive performance.
- Fourth, comparing each numerical-performance condition with the AI-based warning without performance information assesses how explicitly communicating historical predictive performance changes responses relative to a warning that does not disclose such information.

Outcome Measurement

Following the experimental vignette, respondents answer five questions concerning their assessments of escalation risk, the available information, and the proposed military intervention. To

examine how early-warning information shapes citizens' expectations about future violence, we measure perceived escalation likelihood as the primary informational mechanism, alongside a supplementary measure of confidence in the available information.

- First, perceived escalation likelihood is measured by asking respondents how likely they believe the situation would be to escalate into major violence if no foreign intervention were undertaken. Responses range from very unlikely to very likely on a seven-point scale. This measure captures respondents' subjective assessments of the probability of future violence and serves as the principal mediator linking early-warning information to evaluations of preventive humanitarian intervention.

- Second, confidence in the available information is measured by asking respondents how confident they are that the information provides an accurate indication of whether major violence will occur. Responses range from not at all confident to very confident on a seven-point scale. This supplementary measure captures respondents' assessments of the informational reliability of early-warning information, allowing us to examine whether computational forecasts influence not only expectations about future violence but also confidence in the information underlying those expectations.

Although conceptually related, these measures capture distinct aspects of how citizens respond to early-warning information. Perceived escalation likelihood concerns beliefs about the probability of future violence, whereas confidence in the available information concerns the perceived reliability of the information used to assess that risk. Computational forecasts may increase perceived escalation likelihood without necessarily strengthening confidence in the available information, or they may enhance informational confidence without substantially changing expectations about future violence. Examining both outcomes therefore allows us to distinguish changes in perceived conflict risk from changes in the perceived reliability of predictive information. Nevertheless, because our central theoretical argument concerns how forecasts shape expectations about future violence, perceived escalation likelihood serves as the primary informational mechanism in the mediation analyses, while confidence in the available information is examined as a supplementary outcome.

To examine how early-warning information shapes citizens' evaluations of preventive humanitarian intervention, we measure three dependent variables capturing public support for military action, perceived moral responsibility, and acceptability of intervention costs.

- First, support for preventive military intervention serves as the primary dependent variable. Respondents indicate the extent to which they support or oppose the U.S. government carrying out the proposed operation, using a seven-point scale ranging from strongly oppose to strongly support. This measure directly captures citizens' willingness to endorse preventive military action before major violence occurs.

- Second, perceived moral responsibility is measured by asking respondents to what extent carrying out the proposed operation would help fulfill their country's moral responsibility to protect people at risk. Responses are recorded on a seven-point scale ranging from not at all to a very great extent. This measure captures the extent to which respondents regard preventive military intervention as fulfilling a humanitarian obligation.

- Third, cost acceptability is measured by asking respondents how acceptable they consider the financial and military costs of the proposed intervention, given the risk of major

violence. Responses range from not at all acceptable to completely acceptable on a seven-point scale. Because the proposed military commitment is held constant across treatment conditions, this measure captures whether early-warning information influences citizens' willingness to accept the anticipated costs of preventive action.

These dependent variables capture distinct dimensions of public evaluations of preventive humanitarian intervention. Support for intervention reflects citizens' overall policy preferences, whereas perceived moral responsibility and cost acceptability capture evaluations of the humanitarian justification and material burdens associated with preventive action. An early warning may strengthen citizens' sense of moral responsibility or increase their willingness to accept intervention costs without necessarily generating equivalent changes in their overall support for military action. We therefore analyze these outcomes separately to assess whether computational conflict forecasts influence different aspects of public evaluations of preventive intervention.

Numerical Comprehension, Treatment Comprehension, and Information Leakage

Following the experimental treatments and the measurement of the dependent variables, respondents complete a series of supplementary questions assessing numerical comprehension, recognition of treatment information, and associations with real-world conflicts. These questions are administered after the outcome measures to minimize potential priming effects on respondents' evaluations of the experimental information.

First, respondents complete a basic numerical-comprehension question asking them to compare the predictive accuracy of two hypothetical weather forecasting systems. This question assesses respondents' ability to interpret percentage-based performance information and allows us to explore whether numerical comprehension is associated with differential responses to the reported predictive precision of AI-based conflict forecasts. Second, respondents answer two factual treatment-comprehension questions. The first asks which type of information was used to assess escalation risk, distinguishing AI-based assessments, qualitative expert analysis, and the absence of a specified early-warning method.

The second asks whether respondents were informed that major violence followed approximately 60% or 90% of comparable warnings, or whether no historical-performance information was provided. These questions assess respondents' recognition of the randomized warning information rather than directly measuring the theoretical mechanisms underlying the treatment effects.

Finally, respondents complete an open-ended question asking whether the hypothetical scenario brought to mind a particular African country. This question allows us to explore whether respondents associate the unnamed setting with specific real-world cases, potentially informing how they interpret the hypothetical conflict. All eligible respondents will be retained in the primary analyses regardless of their responses to the numerical-comprehension, treatment-comprehension, or information-leakage questions.

6. Analysis Plan

Effects on Perceived Escalation Likelihood and Informational Confidence

Our central theoretical argument proposes that early-warning information influences citizens' evaluations of preventive humanitarian intervention by shaping their subjective expectations about the likelihood of future violence. We therefore examine perceived escalation likelihood as the primary informational outcome and the principal mediator linking randomized warning treatments to perceived moral responsibility, cost acceptability, and support for preventive military intervention. In addition, we assess confidence in the available information as a supplementary outcome to examine whether early-warning assessments influence respondents' evaluations of informational reliability.

To estimate the effects of randomized warning treatments on these two outcomes, we specify the following model:

$$M_{ki} = \alpha_k + \beta_{1k} AI_i + \beta_{2k} AI_i^{60} + \beta_{3k} AI_i^{90} + \beta_{4k} QUAL_i + \varepsilon_{ki},$$

where M_{ki} denotes informational outcome k for respondent i, representing either perceived escalation likelihood or confidence in the available information. The no-warning condition serves as the reference category. We estimate the same prespecified treatment contrasts used in the analyses of intervention-related outcomes, including comparisons between AI-based forecasting and no early warning, AI-based forecasting and qualitative expert warnings, and AI forecasts with 90% versus 60% reported predictive precision.

Treatment Effects on Public Attitudes toward Preventive Actions

Because each respondent evaluates a single randomly assigned vignette, the respondent is the unit of analysis. The primary analyses include eligible respondents who consented to participate and passed the comprehension checks administered before randomization.

The main dependent variable is support for the proposed preventive military intervention, measured on a seven-point scale. We estimate average treatment effects using ordinary least squares (OLS) regression, treating the seven-point response as approximately continuous. We report heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors and 95% confidence intervals. The principal model is specified as:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 AI_i + \beta_2 AI_i^{60} + \beta_3 AI_i^{90} + \beta_4 QUAL_i + \varepsilon_i,$$

where Y_i denotes respondent i's support for preventive military intervention. The treatment indicators represent the AI-based warning without disclosed performance (AI_i), the AI-based warning with 60% precision ($AI60_i$), the AI-based warning with 90% precision ($AI90_i$), and the qualitative expert-based warning ($QUAL_i$). The no-warning condition serves as the omitted reference category. Under random assignment, the treatment coefficients estimate average differences in intervention support relative to the no-warning baseline. We will present estimated means for each experimental condition together with the relevant treatment contrasts and their confidence intervals.

The principal comparisons correspond to the theoretical expectations concerning early-warning information.

- First, the comparison between the AI-based warning without disclosed performance and the no-warning baseline estimates the combined effect of receiving an explicit AI-based early warning. Under the reference-category coding above, this effect is represented by β_1.
- Second, the comparison between the AI-based warning without disclosed performance and the qualitative expert-based warning evaluates whether the informational source of the warning affects public support. The corresponding contrast is:

$$\Delta_{\mathrm{AI-QUAL}} = \beta_1 - \beta_4.$$

- Third, the comparison between the AI-warning conditions reporting 90% and 60% precision identifies the effect of stronger reported predictive performance:

$$\Delta_{90-60} = \beta_3 - \beta_2.$$

- Fourth, we examine the effects of communicating historical predictive performance by comparing the 60% and 90% conditions separately with the AI-based warning that does not disclose performance information:

$$\Delta_{60-\mathrm{AI}} = \beta_2 - \beta_1,$$

$$\Delta_{90-\mathrm{AI}} = \beta_3 - \beta_1.$$

These contrasts distinguish the effects of introducing an early warning, changing its informational source, and communicating numerical evidence about the historical performance of an AI-based forecasting system. To assess robustness, we will additionally estimate covariate-adjusted models incorporating prespecified pretreatment demographic and political characteristics. Because assignment to the warning conditions is randomized, these covariates are not required for identification of the average treatment effects, but may improve precision.

We additionally estimate treatment effects on two secondary outcomes: perceived moral responsibility and acceptability of intervention costs. These analyses investigate whether early-warning information affects broader evaluations of the proposed military intervention. The moral-responsibility measure assesses whether the warning changes the perceived humanitarian justification for preventive action. The cost-acceptability measure evaluates whether information suggesting a greater risk of violence makes respondents more willing to accept the fixed financial and military costs of intervention.

Mediation Analysis

To investigate the proposed informational mechanism, we conduct a causal mediation analysis focusing on perceived escalation likelihood as the principal mediator linking early-warning information to citizens' evaluations of preventive humanitarian intervention. We examine three dependent variables: (1) perceived moral responsibility to protect civilians at risk, (2) acceptability of the financial and military costs of intervention, and (3) public support for preventive military intervention. The central theoretical expectation is that computational conflict forecasts increase the perceived likelihood of future violence, which, in turn, strengthens citizens' sense of moral responsibility, their willingness to accept intervention costs, and their support for preventive action.

The early-warning treatments are randomly assigned, whereas perceived escalation likelihood is measured after treatment and is not independently randomized. Consequently, random treatment assignment identifies the effects of warning information on perceived escalation likelihood and the three dependent variables, but does not, by itself, identify the causal effect of perceived escalation likelihood on these outcomes. We therefore distinguish experimentally identified treatment effects from mediation estimates that depend on additional identification assumptions.

Following the potential-outcomes approach to causal mediation analysis, we estimate indirect effects under the sequential ignorability assumptions, including the absence of unmeasured mediator–outcome confounding conditional on treatment assignment and appropriate pretreatment covariates. The analysis further requires assumptions concerning overlap and the absence of treatment-induced mediator–outcome confounding. Because these assumptions cannot be established solely through experimental randomization, the resulting mediation estimates will be interpreted cautiously.

For each principal treatment contrast, we estimate a mediator model:

$$M_i = \alpha_M + \beta_M T_i + \boldsymbol{\delta}_M^\top \mathbf{Z}_i + \varepsilon_{Mi},$$

and separate outcome models for each dependent variable:

$$Y_{ki} = \alpha_k + \beta_k T_i + \theta_k M_i + \boldsymbol{\delta}_k^\top \mathbf{Z}_i + \varepsilon_{ki},$$

where T_i denotes the relevant randomized treatment contrast, M_i represents perceived escalation likelihood, and Y_{ki} denotes dependent variable k, comprising perceived moral responsibility, cost acceptability, or support for preventive military intervention. The vector $\mathbf{Z}_i$ contains prespecified pretreatment covariates. The coefficient β_M captures the effect of treatment assignment on perceived escalation likelihood, while θ_k represents the conditional association between perceived escalation likelihood and each dependent variable.

These models provide the basis for estimating average causal mediation effects (ACMEs) and average direct effects (ADEs) under the relevant identification assumptions. We will report the estimated indirect and direct effects for each dependent variable, together with 95% confidence intervals. The primary mediation analyses focus on three treatment comparisons: (1) the AI-based warning without disclosed performance versus the no-warning condition, (2) the AI-based warning without disclosed performance versus the qualitative expert-based warning, and (3) the AI-based warning with 90% versus 60% reported predictive precision. These comparisons allow us to examine whether perceived escalation likelihood mediates the effects of receiving computational forecasts, their informational source, and their reported predictive performance on citizens' evaluations of preventive intervention.

To assess the robustness of the mediation findings, we will conduct sensitivity analyses examining how potential violations of the mediator–outcome ignorability assumption affect the estimated indirect effects. Given the observational nature of the mediator–outcome relationship, the mediation estimates will be interpreted as assumption-dependent evidence concerning the proposed informational mechanism rather than definitive identification of causal pathways.

Finally, although perceived moral responsibility and cost acceptability may themselves contribute to public support for preventive intervention, the primary mediation analyses will treat these measures as separate dependent variables rather than additional mediators. This approach allows us to examine whether perceived escalation likelihood helps explain the effects of early-warning information on each dimension of public evaluation without imposing additional assumptions about the causal ordering among post-treatment variables. Any exploratory analyses

examining sequential pathways from perceived escalation likelihood through moral responsibility or cost acceptability to intervention support will be reported separately and interpreted as strongly assumption-dependent.

Moderating Effects of Prior AI Attitudes and Educational Attainment

An additional set of theoretical expectations concerns whether individuals' prior attitudes toward AI and educational attainment condition their responses to AI-based conflict forecasts. We examine these two characteristics as potential moderators of treatment effects, reflecting differences in individuals' predispositions toward computational technologies and their capacity to critically evaluate predictive information.

To measure prior AI attitudes, we construct a composite index using five pretreatment items assessing favorable perceptions of AI's functional capabilities and benefits. The index will be calculated as the unweighted average of the five items, each measured on a seven-point scale, with higher values indicating more favorable attitudes toward AI. All five items will receive equal weight, and the index will be calculated for respondents who provide valid responses to all five items. For the moderation analyses, the resulting index will be standardized to have a mean of zero and a standard deviation of one.

Educational attainment will be measured using six ordered categories reflecting respondents' highest level of completed education, with higher values indicating greater educational attainment. Responses indicating a preference not to disclose educational attainment will be treated as missing. For the primary moderation analyses, the ordinal education measure will be standardized to have a mean of zero and a standard deviation of one. This specification assumes a linear moderating relationship across education categories; we will assess the robustness of the results using categorical representations of educational attainment.

To estimate heterogeneous treatment effects, we separately interact the prespecified treatment contrasts with each moderator. For a given binary treatment comparison, the models are specified as follows:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 T_i + \beta_2 A_i + \beta_3 (T_i \times A_i) + \boldsymbol{\delta}^\top \mathbf{Z}_i + \varepsilon_i,$$

$$Y_i = \alpha + \gamma_1 T_i + \gamma_2 E_i + \gamma_3 (T_i \times E_i) + \boldsymbol{\theta}^\top \mathbf{Z}_i + \varepsilon_i,$$

where T_i denotes the randomized treatment contrast, A_i represents the standardized measure of favorable AI attitudes, and E_i denotes standardized educational attainment. The interaction coefficients β_3 and γ_3 indicate whether the effects of warning assignment vary with respondents' prior attitudes toward AI and educational attainment, respectively. The vectors $\mathbf{Z}_i$ contain the prespecified covariates.

Our principal moderation analyses focus on three treatment comparisons: (1) General AI-based conflict forecasting versus no early warning, (2) General AI-based conflict forecasting versus qualitative warnings from local experts, and (3) AI-based conflict forecasting with 90% versus 60% reported predictive precision. The first two comparisons examine whether AI attitudes and educational attainment moderate the effects of receiving computational forecasts relative to alternative warning conditions. The third evaluates whether these characteristics condition individuals' sensitivity to differences in the reported predictive performance of computational forecasting systems.

We will estimate these interaction effects on perceived likelihood of conflict escalation and public support for preventive humanitarian intervention. To facilitate substantive interpretation, we will report conditional treatment effects and predicted outcomes across observed levels of each moderator, accompanied by 95% confidence intervals.

As supplementary analyses, we will estimate joint interaction models incorporating both AI attitudes and educational attainment to examine whether their moderating relationships persist when accounting for one another. These models will include the corresponding moderator main effects and treatment interactions. Because AI attitudes and educational attainment are observed rather than experimentally manipulated, the interaction estimates will be interpreted as heterogeneity in the causal effects of randomized warning assignment across observed respondent characteristics, rather than as causal effects of AI attitudes or education themselves.

Post-Treatment Checks and Supplementary Analyses

To assess respondents' understanding of the experimental information, comprehension-check questions will be administered after the measurement of the dependent variables. Because these checks are conducted following treatment assignment, respondents' performance may be influenced by the experimental conditions themselves. Restricting the analytical sample based on post-treatment comprehension could therefore introduce selection bias and compromise the comparability established through random assignment (Montgomery et al., 2018; Aronow et al., 2019). Accordingly, the primary analyses will include all eligible randomized respondents with observed outcome measures, regardless of their performance on the comprehension checks. As supplementary analyses, we will reestimate the main treatment effects among respondents who correctly answer the comprehension-check questions to assess the robustness of the findings. These supplementary estimates will be interpreted descriptively rather than as unbiased causal effects for the subgroup of respondents who understood the treatments. We will also report comprehension-check pass rates across experimental conditions and examine whether treatment assignment is associated with the probability of passing these checks.

The survey also includes a numerical-comprehension question concerning the relative accuracy of two weather forecasting systems, administered after the experimental treatments and dependent-variable measurements to minimize potential priming effects. As a supplementary exploratory analysis, we will examine whether responses to reported predictive performance differ between respondents who correctly and incorrectly answer this question. Specifically, we will estimate the interaction between treatment assignment and numerical comprehension when comparing the 90% and 60% precision conditions. Because numerical comprehension is measured after treatment assignment, responses to this question may themselves be influenced by the experimental information. Accordingly, these analyses will be interpreted as descriptive associations rather than as definitive evidence of causal treatment-effect heterogeneity. We will additionally assess whether numerical-comprehension performance differs across experimental conditions.

Finally, we will conduct exploratory analyses of an open-ended information-leakage question to examine whether respondents associate the hypothetical crisis with particular African countries. These analyses will help assess the extent to which respondents draw on preexisting knowledge or associations when interpreting the experimental scenario. Responses to this question will be used to characterize respondents' interpretations of the vignette rather than to determine their inclusion in the primary analysis sample. Overall, the primary conclusions will be based on randomized treatment contrasts estimated using the full prespecified analysis sam-

ple, while the supplementary analyses will provide additional evidence concerning respondents' comprehension, interpretation, and sensitivity to the experimental information.

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Survey Questionnaires

Consent Check

This research study aims to enhance our understanding of personal attitudes towards political matters. To accomplish this, we will administer a brief questionnaire to individuals living in the United States. The survey will take approximately 5–10 minutes.

The questionnaire is completely anonymous: your answers cannot be traced back to you and will be kept confidential. There are no significant risks associated with participating in this survey.

You may leave the survey at any point if you feel uncomfortable with any question. If you choose to exit without finishing, your answers will not be saved. Once you submit, you cannot retract your responses because the survey is anonymous.

Please note that if you do not answer the consent or attention-check question correctly, the survey may conclude at that point without proceeding further.

Q1. Are you eligible for this survey, and do you agree to participate?

- Yes (1); No (2)

Pre-treatment Survey Questions

Q2. What is your gender?

- Male (1); Female (2); Non-binary / third gender (3); Prefer not to say (4)

Q3. What is your age?

- 18–29 (1); 30–39 (2); 40–49 (3); 50–59 (4); 60 or above (5)

Q4-1. (US) Choose one or more races that you consider yourself to be.

- White or Caucasian (1); Black or African American (2); American Indian/Native American or Alaska Native (3); Asian (4); Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander (5); Other (6); Prefer not to say (7)

Q5-1. (US) What is the highest level of education you have completed?

- Some high school or less (1); High school diploma or GED (2); Some college, but no degree (3); Associates or technical degree (4); Bachelor's degree (5); Graduate or professional degree (MA, MS, MBA, PhD, JD, MD, DDS, etc.) (6); Prefer not to say (7)

Q6-1. (US) What was your total household income before taxes during the past 12 months?

- Less than $25,000 (1); $25,000–$49,999 (2); $50,000–$74,999 (3); $75,000–$99,999 (4); $100,000–$149,999 (5); $150,000 or more (6); Prefer not to say (7)

Q7-1. (US) In which state do you currently reside?
Dropdown: Alabama (1) . . . I do not reside in the United States (53).

Q8-1. (US) Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a Republican, Democrat, or Independent?

- Republican (1); Democrat (2); Independent (3); Other party (4); No preference (5); Don't know (6)

Q9. [Pre-treatment Attention Check] Please choose two options that include the word "Somewhat." This question is designed to check how much a respondent pays attention to this survey.

- Agree (1); Somewhat Agree (2); Neither Agree nor Disagree (3); Somewhat Disagree (4); Disagree (5)

Q10. In general, how would you describe your political views?

- Conservative (1); Somewhat Conservative (2); Neither Conservative nor Liberal (3); Somewhat Liberal (4); Liberal (5)

Q12. Please indicate how much you agree or disagree with each statement.
[Responses: Strongly disagree (1) – Strongly agree (7)]

- There are many beneficial applications of Artificial Intelligence.
- Artificially intelligent systems can perform better than humans.
- Much of society will benefit from a future full of Artificial Intelligence.
- An artificially intelligent agent would be better than an employee in many routine jobs.
- Some complex decisions are best left to artificially intelligent systems.

Treatment Vignette

We will present a scenario regarding a political event in a foreign country. Some aspects of the scenario may seem significant to you, while others may not. Please adjust your speakers or headphones to a comfortable volume. The following content will be presented in both written and audio form.

Q14. Do you agree to read the details very carefully, and then give your most thoughtful answers? [Yes, No]

Humanitarian Crisis Scenario:

Imagine that a civil war may be developing in a foreign country in Africa. Tensions have existed between the government and an armed opposition group, but large-scale fighting has not yet begun.

If the situation escalates into major violence, at least several hundred people are expected to be killed during its initial stages. Most of the victims would be civilians living in the affected areas, including people who are not directly involved in the fighting. Civilians may also be deliberately targeted as the conflict intensifies.

[Pre-treatment Attention Check] Before continuing, we need to make sure you read this information carefully.

Q15. What is the current situation?
(1) Large-scale fighting between the government and a rebel group has already begun.
(2) Large-scale fighting between the government and a rebel group has not yet begun.
(3) The conflict has already ended

Q16. According to the scenario, what would be the main consequence if the situation escalated into major violence?
(1) Civilian casualties.
(2) Economic collapse.
(3) Collapse of the government.

Treatment: Warning condition

The survey makes a transition into a government statement regarding humanitarian intervention into the situation.

Regarding the situation, a U.S. government official made the following announcement.

(1) Baseline without early-warning:

We are closely monitoring ongoing tensions between the government and an armed opposition group in the country. Although tensions remain high, large-scale violence has not yet occurred.

Given the ongoing tensions in the country, the U.S. government is considering deploying military forces to prevent major violence. We estimate that such an operation would require approximately 5,000 U.S. military personnel and cost around $1 billion.

(2) Early Warning with AI-based Forecasting (precision undisclosed)

We are closely monitoring ongoing tensions between the government and an armed opposition group in the country. Although tensions remain high, large-scale violence has not yet occurred.

However, we have recently received a warning that major violence is very likely

to occur in the near future. This warning is based on an early-warning assessment conducted using artificial intelligence. The AI-based system analyzed a wide range of political, economic, security, and conflict-related information from the country and concluded that the likelihood of escalation into major violence within the next few months is extremely high.

Given this early warning, the U.S. government is considering deploying military forces to prevent major violence. We estimate that such an operation would require approximately 5,000 U.S. military personnel and cost around $1 billion.

(3) Early Warning with AI-based Forecasting (60% precision)

We are closely monitoring ongoing tensions between the government and an armed opposition group in the country. Although tensions remain high, large-scale violence has not yet occurred.

However, we have recently received a warning that major violence is very likely to occur in the near future. This warning is based on an early-warning assessment conducted using artificial intelligence. The AI-based system analyzed a wide range of political, economic, security, and conflict-related information from the country and concluded that the likelihood of escalation into major violence within the next few months is extremely high. The system has a precision of about 60%. In other words, when it issued this type of warning in the past, major violence occurred in about 6 out of 10 similar cases.

Given this early warning, the U.S. government is considering deploying military forces to prevent major violence. We estimate that such an operation would require approximately 5,000 U.S. military personnel and cost around $1 billion.

(4) Early Warning with AI-based Forecasting (90% precision)

We are closely monitoring ongoing tensions between the government and an armed opposition group in the country. Although tensions remain high, large-scale violence has not yet occurred.

However, we have recently received a warning that major violence is very likely to occur in the near future. This warning is based on an early-warning assessment conducted using artificial intelligence. The AI-based system analyzed a wide range of political, economic, security, and conflict-related information from the country and concluded that the likelihood of escalation into major violence within the next few months is extremely high. The system has a precision of about 90%. In other words, when it issued this type of warning in the past, major violence occurred in about 9 out of 10 similar cases.

Given this early warning, the U.S. government is considering deploying military forces to prevent major violence. We estimate that such an operation would require approximately 5,000 U.S. military personnel and cost around $1 billion.

(5) Early warning with Qualitative Evidence

We are closely monitoring ongoing tensions between the government and an armed opposition group in the country. Although tensions remain high, large-scale violence has not yet occurred.

However, we have recently received a warning that major violence is very likely to occur in the near future. This warning is based on an early-warning assessment conducted by regional conflict experts using field reports and contextual analysis. The experts reviewed reports from local NGOs, community leaders, and other sources familiar with conditions on the ground and concluded that the likelihood of escalation into major violence within the next few months is extremely high.

Given this early warning, the U.S. government is considering deploying military forces to prevent major violence. We estimate that such an operation would require approximately 5,000 U.S. military personnel and cost around $1 billion.

Post-treatment Measurement

- If no foreign intervention were undertaken, how likely do you think it is that the situation would escalate into major violence? [Very unlikely (1) – Very likely (7)]
- How confident are you that the available information provides an accurate indication of whether major violence will occur? [Not at all confident (1) – Very confident (7)]
- To what extent would you support or oppose your government carrying out this operation? [Strongly oppose (1) – Strongly support (7)]
- To what extent do you think carrying out the proposed intervention would help fulfill your country's moral responsibility to protect people at risk in this situation? [Not at all (1) – To a very great extent (7)]
- How acceptable do you think the financial and military costs of the proposed intervention are, given the risk of major violence? [Not at all acceptable (1) – Completely acceptable (7)]
- According to the scenario, what type of information was used to assess the risk of major violence?
  (1) No specific early-warning method was described.
  (2) An AI-based early-warning system.
  (3) Analyses by local experts, NGOs, and community leaders.
  (4) Not sure
- According to the scenario, what information was provided about how often major violence followed similar warnings?
  (1) About 60%
  (2) About 90%

(3) No information about previous warning performance was provided

(4) Not sure

- Two weather forecasting systems predict whether it will rain. System A's predictions are correct 50% of the time, while System B's predictions are correct 80% of the time. Which system makes more accurate predictions?

  (1) System A

  (2) System B

  (3) Both systems have the same percentage of correct predictions

  (4) Not sure

- Is there a specific foreign country in Africa that comes to mind as you read the scenario above? If so, please write the name of the country. If not, please type "NA."